After two months in Umerkot, Humayun rode away under a waxing moon towards Bhakkar* with the rana, while Hamida Banu was left behind in the fort with the rest of the harem under the charge of her brother, Khwaja Muazzam. The most senior woman of the household at this time was Khanzada Begum, eldest sister of Babur. Three days later, on the full moon night of 15 October 1542, Hamida Banu delivered a baby boy. 'The moon was in Leo,' wrote Gulbadan, 'it was of a very good omen that the birth was in a fixed Sign.' This brisk account of the birth of the future Shadow of God was not, however, expansive enough for Abu'l Fazl. In his chronicle of the Padshah's life, the *Akbarnama*, the event is much more precisely placed within a cosmological framework that concorded with the radiant destiny of this infant boy. As Hamida Banu laboured to deliver her child, wrote Abu'l Fazl, the astrologer, Maulana Chand, 'was perturbed as the moment was inauspicious. "In a short time, a glorious moment will arrive, such as does not happen once in a thousand years,"' he assured the doubtful women, and urged them to delay the labour. Fortuitously, at that very moment, a particularly homely-looking midwife walked into the room, so disgusting Hamida Banu that her labours were arrested. And so it happened that a commonplace hour was averted and Hamida Banu did indeed give birth to Akbar at Maulana Chand's 'glorious moment'. A runner was sent to convey the good news to Humayun who, according to much later accounts from Akbar's court, 'fell a'dancing, and from excess of exultation, revolved with a circular motion' because he had realized that the 'horoscope of this Light of Fortune was superior, in several respects and by sundry degrees, to that of his Majesty, the Lord of Conjunction (Timur)'. Humayun then broke a pod of musk and distributed it amongst his amirs saying; 'This is all the present I can afford to make you on the birth of my son, whose fame will, I trust, be one day expanded all over the worlds as the perfume of the musk now fills this apartment.'

In Umerkot, a veritable tribe of women was now appointed to suckle the infant. Jiji Anaga, wife of Shamsuddin Muhammad of Ghazni, was singled out for this important and highly coveted task. This was done in gratitude, for her husband had saved Humayun from drowning at the battle of Kanauj. These women were to supply not only their life-giving milk but also, it was believed, some of their virtuous qualities. But Jiji Anaga was not immediately able to suckle the newborn as she was herself pregnant with the future Mirza Aziz Koka, Akbar's milk brother. At least ten additional